Lesson 36: Posters and Talks

English Stage 4 (Psychology) · Unit 5: Writing and Presenting Research in APA Style

Adapted from Research Methods in Psychology (4th American edition) by Rajiv S. Jhangiani, I-Chant A. Chiang, Carrie Cuttler and Dana C. Leighton (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 11.4 Other Presentation Formats; 11.5 Presenting Your Research (Summary).

In this lesson

An empirical research report is only one way to present research. You will learn about review and theoretical articles, final manuscripts such as theses, and the two formal ways of presenting at professional conferences: talks and posters. You will plan a poster and give a five-minute talk in a tone that is "less formal than APA-style writing but more formal than a conversation with a friend".

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Distinguish review articles, theoretical articles and final manuscripts from empirical research reports.
- Explain the purpose of talks and posters at professional conferences.
- Plan a poster that follows the book's guidelines on sections, layout and font size.
- Write a conference abstract, and give a five-minute talk with no more than five slides.
- Use the language of recommendation and comparison found in the section.

Key language

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
review article	an article that summarizes research on a topic without presenting new empirical results	no method or results section
theoretical article	a journal article in which the author presents a new theory or evaluates existing theories	no method or results section either
final manuscript	a manuscript (such as a dissertation, thesis or student paper) prepared in its final form that will not be submitted for publication	your proposal
professional conference	a meeting at which researchers in a particular field gather to share their research	the APA Convention
oral presentation ("talk")	a conference presentation in which presenters stand in front of an audience and tell them about their research, usually with a slide show	10 to 20 minutes, with questions at the end

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
poster session	a one- or two-hour session at a conference in which several researchers present their posters, often on related topics	one to two hours, in a large room
abstract	a short summary of the research; for a conference, submitted in advance	about 200 words
peer review	review of new research by two or more experts before an editor decides whether to publish it	less rigorous for conferences
visual aid	something the audience looks at to support what the speaker says	"they should act as visual aids"
bulleted points	short lines of text, each after a symbol	"sentences or bulleted points rather than paragraphs"
in essence	basically	"In essence, poster sessions are a grown-up version of the school science fair."
among the reasons ... is that	introduces one of several reasons	"Among the reasons posters are so popular is that they encourage meaningful interaction among researchers."

Rules and explanations

The ideas

Other types of manuscripts

Type	What it is	Difference from an empirical research report
Review article	summarizes research on a topic	no method or results section; the body has an opening (topic and importance), a literature review (relationships among concepts, gaps in the literature) and a closing (conclusions, directions, implications); headings vary from article to article
Theoretical article	a review article that presents a new theory	as above, with much of the body devoted to the new theory
Final manuscript	dissertation, thesis or other student paper, in final form	may be easier to read, for example with tables and figures close to where they are discussed; check the format with your instructor (in a research methods course, papers are usually written as if for publication)

> **APA 7th edition:** The book contrasts final manuscripts with manuscripts submitted to a journal ("copy manuscripts" in its learning objectives). The 7th edition distinguishes student papers from professional papers instead, and allows tables and figures in the text in both.

Conference presentations. Conferences range from a dozen researchers meeting for an afternoon to thousands meeting for several days. Besides informal discussion, there are two formal types of presentation, talks and posters. Both usually require an abstract submitted in advance and accepted, although this peer review is typically less rigorous than for journal manuscripts.

Talks last 10 to 20 minutes, with the last few minutes for questions; at large conferences they are grouped into sessions of an hour or two on the same topic. Three principles:

1. No more than about one slide per minute.
2. The structure of an APA-style report: a title-and-authors slide, then a few slides each for background, method, results and conclusions.
3. Look at the audience and speak in a conversational tone, less formal than APA writing but more formal than talking with a friend. Slides are visual aids, not the focus: main points in bulleted lists or simple tables and figures.

Posters

- A poster session lasts one to two hours in a large room: presenters stand by their posters on bulletin boards, and other researchers walk around, read and talk. At a recent American Psychological Association conference, nearly 2,000 posters were presented in 16 sessions. Posters are popular because they encourage meaningful interaction among researchers.
- Size: about 4 feet wide and 3 feet high (about 120 by 90 cm).
- Sections: title; authors' names and affiliations; introduction; method; results; discussion or conclusions; references; acknowledgments. An abstract may be unnecessary, because the poster is already a brief summary.
- Design for a crowded room: the main ideas as simply as possible; large fonts (perhaps 72 points for the title and names, 28 points for the main text); clear headings; sentences or bullet points, not paragraphs; columns that flow from top to bottom, so that several people can read at once without bumping into each other; colorful figures, stimuli or photographs of the apparatus; decoration, but not too much.
- The presenter stands by the poster, greets visitors, offers to answer questions, is ready for critical comments, and has a detailed write-up available (or offers to send one, or gives contact information).

The book's figure of two poster layouts is a picture. A column layout that follows the text: title, names and affiliation across the top; then column 1, Introduction; column 2, Method; column 3, Results, Conclusions and References.

Summary (11.5). Talks and posters follow some APA style guidelines but are much less detailed than reports. Their function is to present new research to interested researchers and to facilitate further interaction among them.

Language focus

1. Recommending. The section gives advice in several ways:

- *should*: "the number of slides should be no more than about one per minute"; "The font sizes on a poster should be large"
- *it is better (for it) to … rather than …*: "It is also better for it to be organized in columns … rather than to be organized in rows"
- *it is best not to*: "it is best not to overdo these"
- *at the very least, it is important (for X) to*: "At the very least, it is important for presenters to stand by their posters"
- *it is generally a good idea to*: "It is generally a good idea to have a more detailed write-up of the research available"

2. Listing and comparing. Ordinals organize the advice: "The first is that … The second is that … The third is that …". A double comparison places the tone of a talk precisely: "*less formal than* APA-style writing *but more formal than* a conversation with a friend".

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
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> - Standard Arabic has no /p/ or /v/ sounds, so they can become /b/ and /f/ when you speak. Before your talk, practise the words you will repeat most: *poster, participants, presentation, proposal, previous, visual, variable, validity, survey*.

Practice

1. Reading questions

1. How do review and theoretical articles differ from empirical research reports, and what must they still have?
2. What are final manuscripts, and how may they differ from manuscripts submitted for publication?
3. What must a researcher usually do before presenting at a conference?
4. How long do talks last? How many slides should a 15-minute talk have at most?
5. What should slides contain?
6. Why are posters becoming so popular?
7. Why should a poster's text be organized in columns that flow from top to bottom?
8. Why may a poster not need an abstract?
9. What should a presenter do during a poster session?

2. Book exercise and an application task

1. "Discussion: Do an Internet search using search terms such as *psychology* and *poster* to find three examples of posters that have been presented at conferences. Based on information in this chapter, what are the main strengths and main weaknesses of each poster?"
2. Which guideline from 11.4 does each case break? (a) A 15-minute talk with 30 slides. (b) A poster with the main text in 12-point type. (c) The speaker reads long paragraphs from the slides. (d) Poster sections arranged in rows across the whole poster. (e) The presenter sits at a nearby table, checking a phone.

3. Language exercise

1. Write the advice as full sentences with the phrases in brackets: (a) paragraphs on a poster (*it is better to … rather than …*); (b) decoration (*it is best not to*); (c) contact information (*it is a good idea to*).
2. Make these sentences sound right for a talk (more conversational, still not casual): (a) "These considerations lead to the hypothesis that the more bystanders to an emergency, the less likely, or the more slowly, any one bystander will intervene to provide aid." (11.3) (b) "Presenting a talk or poster at a conference usually requires submitting an abstract of the research to the conference organizers in advance and having it accepted for presentation." (11.4)

Speak with your tutor

- "Let me explain how review articles, theoretical articles and empirical research reports differ. Correct my explanation and my English."
- "Here is my poster plan: [paste]. Check it against the book's guidelines: sections, columns, font sizes, bullet points."
- "Be a visitor at my poster. Ask me three questions about my study, including one critical comment, and then tell me how to answer more clearly."
- "Here is my talk (I will speak it into the microphone): tell me where my tone was too formal, like a written report, or too casual."

Writing task

Your research project: a poster abstract and a five-minute talk. Present your proposal on sleep and memory in university students (or your own topic).

1. **Conference abstract** (150 to 200 words, one paragraph, title above it): the research question and why it matters; the planned method (for the default topic: 20 students, a nap or a wake condition after learning 40 word pairs, recall out of 40); the expected results (if you use your Lesson 32 numbers, such as $t(18) = 3.95$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.86$, label them "invented data for practice"); the main implication. Use the present tense for the aim ("This study examines …") and the future for the plan ("Participants will …").
2. **Poster plan** (one page): your title, names and affiliation across the top, then three columns, with the sections and their bullet points written out.
3. **Five-minute talk** with no more than five slides: title; background and hypothesis; method; expected results; conclusions. Write short notes for each slide, not a script to read. Use spoken signposts: "Let me start with …", "This brings me to …", "So what do we expect?", "To sum up, …". Practise twice and time yourself. Then give the talk to your tutor with the microphone (your speech is transcribed), or record it on your phone, listen once, and then give it. Finally, ask your tutor to ask you questions as a conference audience would.

Self-editing checklist:

- The abstract covers the question, method, expected results and implication in 150 to 200 words.

- Invented numbers are labelled.
- The poster has all the book's sections, bullet points, columns from top to bottom, and 72-point and 28-point type.
- The talk has five slides at most, with bulleted points or one simple figure each.
- The talk follows the order of an APA report and lasts about five minutes.
- I speak to the listener, in a tone between a report and a chat, with clear signposts.
- I have answers ready for three likely questions, including one critical one.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The APA Convention, a large conference with talks and poster sessions: https://www.apa.org/convention
- A list of psychology conferences worldwide (the new address of the book's link): https://conferencealerts.com/topic-listing?topic=Psychology

Answer key

1. Reading questions

1. They report no new empirical research, so they have no method or results section; they still have a title page, abstract, references, appendixes, tables and figures, the same high- and low-level style, and a logically organized body (opening, literature review, closing). Their headings vary from article to article.
2. Dissertations, theses and other student papers prepared in final form with no plan to submit them for publication; they may be easier to read, for example with tables and figures near where they are discussed.
3. Submit an abstract to the organizers in advance and have it accepted.
4. Usually 10 to 20 minutes, with the last few minutes for questions; at most about 15 slides.
5. The main points, in bulleted lists or simple tables and figures.
6. They encourage meaningful interaction among researchers.
7. Several people can then read it at the same time without bumping into each other.
8. The poster itself is already a brief summary of the research.
9. Stand by the poster, greet visitors, offer to answer questions, be prepared for questions and critical comments, and have a detailed write-up or contact information available.

2. Book exercise and application task

1. (example answer) Strengths to look for: a title readable from a distance, clear headings, columns from top to bottom, bullet points, one clear figure for the main result, references and contact information. Weaknesses: long paragraphs, small type, rows across the poster, crowded or decorative design, no clear conclusion. Your three posters will differ.
2. (a) no more than about one slide per minute; (b) about 28 points for the main text; (c) slides are visual aids with bulleted points, and the speaker looks at the audience; (d) columns that flow from top to bottom; (e) stand by the poster and greet visitors.

3. Language exercise

1. (example answers) (a) It is better to use bullet points or short sentences on a poster rather than paragraphs. (b) It is best not to add too many decorative elements. (c) It is a good idea to give visitors your contact information so that they can request more information later.
2. (example answers) (a) "So we predicted this: when more people see an emergency, each person is less likely to help, or slower to help." (b) "To present at a conference, you usually send the organizers an abstract first, and they have to accept it."

My notes